

The Ruin and the Road

*A Tisha b'Av Readers Theater and Study
Booklet*

Inspired by Berakhot 3a and Eikhah (Lamentations)

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For Tisha b'Av study and worship

1. Introduction

On Tisha b'Av, we sit in the ruins—of the Temple, of our people's traumas, and of our own world's unraveling. This booklet offers a readers theater piece, commentary, and musical and ritual guides for synagogue use. It weaves the Talmudic story of Rabbi Yosi and Elijah with Lamentations and our contemporary experience

of crumbling institutions, broken trust, and violence in word and deed.

Three themes carry this story. They are ancient words. They are also the words we reach for when everything else has been taken away.

Devotion — דְּבִיקוּת

D'veikut — cleaving, holding fast

“But you who cleave to the Lord your God are alive, every one of you, this day.”

— Deuteronomy 4:4

Sit with this a moment.

Faith — אֱמוּנָה

Emunah — faithfulness, steadiness

“The steadfast love of the Lord never ceases; His mercies never come to an end. They are new every morning.”

— Lamentations 3:22–23

Sit with this a moment.

Hope — תִּקְוָה

Tikvah — hope, a thread held taut

“This I call to mind, and therefore I have hope.”

— Lamentations 3:21

Sit with this a moment.

2. The Source: Berakhot 3a

This play is a midrash—a retelling—rooted in a brief and extraordinary passage from the Talmud. Here is the original story.

Hebrew

תָּנִינָא, אָמַר רַבִּי יוֹסִי: פַּעַם אַחַת הָיִיתִי מְהֻלָּךְ בְּדֶרֶךְ
וְנִכְנַסְתִּי לְחוּרְבָה אַחַת מִחוּרְבוֹת יְרוּשָׁלַיִם לְהִתְפַּלֵּל.
בָּא אֵלָיָהּ זָכוֹר לְטוֹב וְשָׁמַר לִי עַל הַפֶּתַח, עַד שֶׁסִּימַמְתִּי
תְּפִלָּתִי. לְאַחֵר שֶׁסִּימַמְתִּי תְּפִלָּתִי אָמַר לִי: שְׁלוֹם עָלֶיךָ,
רַבִּי. וְאָמַרְתִּי לוֹ: שְׁלוֹם עָלֶיךָ, רַבִּי וּמוֹרִי. וְאָמַר לִי:
בְּנִי, מִפְּנֵי מָה נִכְנַסְתָּ לְחוּרְבָה זוֹ? אָמַרְתִּי לוֹ:
לְהִתְפַּלֵּל. וְאָמַר לִי: הִנֵּה לָךְ לְהִתְפַּלֵּל בְּדֶרֶךְ. וְאָמַרְתִּי

לו: מַתְּנָא הֵייתִי שְׂמָא יַפְסִיקוּ בִּי עוֹבְרֵי דְרָכִים.
 וְאָמַר לִי: הֲיָה לָּךְ לְהַתְּפִלָּל תְּפִלָּה קְצָרָה. וְאָמַר לִי:
 בְּנִי, מָה קוֹל שְׂמַעְתָּ בְּחוּרְבָּה זֶה? וְאָמַרְתִּי לוֹ: שְׂמַעְתִּי
 בֵּת קוֹל שְׂמִנְהָמַת כְּיוֹנָה וְאֹמְרָת: אוֹי שְׁהַחְרַבְתִּי אֶת
 בֵּיתִי וְשָׂרַפְתִּי אֶת הַיִּכְלִי וְהַגְלִיתִי אֶת בְּנֵי לְבִין אוֹמוֹת
 הָעוֹלָם. וְאָמַר לִי: חַיִּיה וְחַיֵּי רֵאשָׁה, לֹא שָׁעָה זֶה בְּלִבְד
 אוֹמְרָת כֹּךְ, אֲלֹא בְּכָל יוֹם וַיּוֹם, שְׁלֹשׁ פְּעָמִים אוֹמְרָת
 כֹּךְ.

English

It was taught in a baraita that Rabbi Yosi said: Once I was walking along the road when I entered one of the ruins among the ruins of Jerusalem to pray. Elijah, of blessed memory, came and guarded the entrance for me until I finished my prayer. After I finished my prayer he said to me: "Greetings to you, my rabbi." I answered him: "Greetings to you, my rabbi, my teacher." And he said to me: My son, why did you enter this ruin? I said to him: To pray. And

he said to me: You should have prayed on the road. And I said to him: I was afraid that travelers might interrupt me. And he said to me: You should have recited an abbreviated prayer. And he said to me: My son, what voice did you hear in this ruin? I responded: I heard a Heavenly voice, cooing like a dove and saying: “Woe to the children, due to whose sins I destroyed My house, burned My Temple, and exiled them among the nations of the world.” And he said to me: By your life and by your head, not only at this moment does it say thus, but rather every single day, three times does it say thus.

— Babylonian Talmud, Berakhot 3a

Notes on the Source

“One of the ruins of Jerusalem”

Rabbi Yosi doesn't enter *the* great ruin—the Temple Mount. He enters an ordinary *ḥurvah*, one nameless wreck among many. This is not a grand

confrontation with destruction; it is an ordinary person stepping into an ordinary ruin, looking for a quiet place to pray. That ordinariness is the point. Our play honors this: Mara does not stand before the Temple. She stands before *her* ruin—the one that was specifically hers to lose.

Elijah guards the door but does not enter

This detail is easy to miss. Elijah waits at the threshold. He does not join Rabbi Yosi inside. The holy stranger stands at the margin of the destruction, not within it. In our play, the Stranger appears in the dim light outside the ruin—not inside. The Talmud places holiness at the edge, not at the center of the collapse.

“You should have prayed on the road”

Elijah’s first correction is not theological—it is practical and urgent. *Do not stay in the ruin*. Pray where your feet can move. This single phrase is the seed from which the entire play grows. The Stranger’s line — “*On the road. Where your feet can move. Where breath can return*” — is a direct expansion of these six Talmudic words.

“You should have recited an abbreviated prayer”

The Talmud's concession to human limitation—that a shortened, honest prayer is not a lesser prayer—becomes in our play a full theology: “*A single honest word is holier than a thousand perfect ones.*” This is not a modern invention. It is already in the Talmud, waiting to be unpacked.

The bat kol — the Heavenly voice cooing like a dove

The divine voice is not majestic here. It moans. It coos like a dove. It grieves. The Talmud insists that Hashem does not observe destruction from a distance—Hashem laments it, three times a day, every day. Our play gives voice to this grief: “*Even the Holy One cries—for every soul wounded in a place meant to be safe.*” The dove is not decoration. It is the bat kol of the Talmud, brought forward into this room, on this night.

Three times a day

Elijah's final statement is quietly staggering: this lament is not a one-time cry at the moment of destruction. It echoes three times daily, across all of history, and is still echoing now. Tisha b'Av is not a commemoration of something that ended. It

is one night when we tune our ears to a grief that has never stopped.

3. A Note on Mara

She has been here before.

In this reading, Mara is Naomi—once a Nazirite, bound by vow to the shrine at Bethlehem. She came there as a young unmarried woman, drawn by devotion rather than obligation. It was at the shrine that she met Elimelech—a scion of a wealthy family who had turned his back on inheritance to sit with Torah. Their love grew quietly, in the margins of the sanctuary, between prayers.

The Kohen did not approve. Elimelech's family wealth was bound up with the shrine's economy, and a man who preferred study to commerce was a disruption the Kohen could not afford. So he manufactured a scandal—whispered accusations, a false account of dishonor—and brought it before the council. Naomi's Nazirite

vows were annulled. The couple was pushed to the margins of Judean life. When armies pressed in from the east, they fled to Moab.

In Moab the family found footing. Her sons Mahlon and Chilion married well. Then the boys died. Elimelech died too.

She returned to Judah—not alone. Ruth, her Moabite daughter-in-law, refused to leave her side. Ruth is not in this scene. She waits at the inn at the edge of Bethlehem, patient and lovely, faithful as morning. Naomi came ahead alone, pulled by something she could not name—a need to return to the place where everything began and everything was taken.

She came back to the shrine at Bethlehem. She found it desecrated. Idols where the altar had been. Silence where there had been song. The institution that had betrayed her was a ruin. And so, she thought, was she.

This is where Elijah finds her. At the one broken place that had once been completely hers—where she had first prayed, first loved, and first been broken by someone who wore the robes of holiness.

The stranger does not tell her to rebuild it. He tells her to turn. This is her *Teshuvah*—not a grand return, not a rebuilt altar, but a turning of the heart. Back toward Hashem. Back toward the road, and the lovely Moabite daughter waiting at the inn, who has shown her more faithful love than any shrine ever did.

אַל תִּקְרְאֵנִי לִי נַעֲמִי קְרְאֵנִי לִי מָרָא

*“Do not call me Naomi; call me Mara.” — Ruth
1:20*

She comes to this story carrying all three: the devotion that brought her back, the faith she is not sure she still has, and the hope she has not yet found words for.

4. Tisha b’Av Ritual Guide

Purpose

This ritual frames *The Ruin and the Road* as a modern midrash for Tisha b’Av: we acknowledge destruction, listen for Hashem’s grief, and seek

the faintest glimmer of a road forward. The play moves through D'veikut, Emunah, and Tikvah—not as answers, but as the questions a broken heart still dares to ask.

A Note to the Leader

Present the three theme readings before the play begins. Allow the silence after each to settle fully—at least 30 seconds—before moving to the next. These are not preamble. They are preparation.

Atmosphere

- **Lighting:** Dim, with a single focal light for the readers.
- **Seating:** Congregation seated low (floor or low stools).
- **Sound:** Soft shruti box drone prelude in a minor mode.
- **Conduct:** No greetings; quiet entry and exit.

Opening Ritual

Leader reads:

“On this night we remember every place that was meant to be safe but was not. Every institution that failed. Every word sharpened into a weapon. Every act of violence that tore the fabric of creation. We sit in the ruins—not to stay there, but to listen.

We carry three things into this darkness: the devotion that brings us back even when we are broken, the faith we are not sure we still have, and the hope we have not yet found words for.

We begin.”

Hold silence for 30–60 seconds, then begin the readers theater.

Four voices: NARRATOR • MARA • STRANGER • LYRE PLAYER

The Shruti Box Player plays a sustained drone throughout; harmonium or accordion may substitute. Readers sit or stand in a line facing the congregation. No movement is required.

*Music cues are marked **CUE A** • **CUE B** • etc.*
*At **CUE E** (“Lament” by Rabbi Shefa Gold), the*
congregation joins in the round and is invited to call
out laments between repetitions.

5. Readers Theater: “The Ruin and the Road”

NARRATOR

CUE A On Tisha b’Av, we sit in the ruins—of the Temple, of our people’s traumas, and of our own world’s unraveling. Tonight we hear a midrash retold: a woman, a holy stranger, a dove, and a melody older than sorrow.

SHRUTI BOX PLAYER

(softly, as if plucking) Some ruins echo louder than they speak.

NARRATOR

Mara stands before a boarded-up shrine—a place that once promised safety and instead delivered harm. A dove watches from a tree above.

MARA

I thought if I came back here... maybe I'd understand why it happened. But it's just a ruin now. And I feel like one too.

NARRATOR

A quiet presence steps into the dim light.

STRANGER

My daughter... why did you come to this place?

MARA

To pray. Or to scream. Or to ask why the world keeps breaking. Why people keep breaking each other. Why the places meant to protect us are the ones that crumble first.

STRANGER

This place is dangerous for you.

MARA

I know. But it's where I lost everything I trusted. And I thought maybe holiness still lived in the cracks.

STRANGER

Holiness does not live in ruins. Only memory does. And memory can collapse on you like a

roof that was never repaired.

NARRATOR

CUE B The dove coos—a low, mournful sound.

MARA

Do you hear that? It sounds like crying.

STRANGER

It is crying. The world cries with you. Even the Holy One cries—for every soul wounded in a place meant to be safe, for every institution that forgot its purpose, for every word sharpened into a blade, for every act of violence that tears the fabric of creation.

MARA

I thought Hashem abandoned us.

STRANGER

Hashem stood outside the door you could not escape. And Hashem stands with you now. But Hashem will not let you stay in the ruin.

MARA

Then where am I supposed to pray?

STRANGER

CUE C On the road. Where your feet can move.
Where breath can return. Where healing can
walk beside you. Where hope is fragile but real.

MARA

And if I can't pray the whole prayer?

STRANGER

Then shorten it. A single honest word is holier
than a thousand perfect ones.

NARRATOR

Mara takes one small step away from the ruin.
The dove flutters its wings above. The melody
shifts—still mournful, but with a thread of dawn.

MARA

I'm not ready. But I'm willing.

STRANGER

That is enough. For now, that is the whole
prayer.

NARRATOR

CUE D And so they walk—not far, not fast—but
forward. A voice rises from the gathering,
singing:

CUE E (*“Lament” by Rabbi Shefa Gold begins
— the group joins in the round*)

*How my heart has been broken by the cruelty of
this world*

*How my heart has been broken by the beauty of
this world*

אֵיכָה יָשְׁבָה בָּדָד

*Eicha yashva vadad — How she sits alone!
(Lamentations 1:1)*

*Between repetitions of the round, each person in
the circle is invited to cry out a lament — a
heartbreak, personal or communal: suffering,
loss, injustice, violence, grief... The round
continues beneath and between each voice.*

Closing Ritual

After the final round of “Lament,” allow the
music to fade and hold silence. The leader may
say:

*“And yet... all of this sends us
to kindness—*

*to connection—
to compassion—
and to the knowing of the preciousness of
all life.”*

Hold the silence. Softly turn up lights and move to the discussion prompts below.

6. Symbolic Commentary

The Ruin

The boarded-up shrine is the modern *ḥurvah*—a sacred space that failed to protect. It mirrors the desolation of Jerusalem in Lamentations: “Her gates have sunk into the ground” (2:9). It represents betrayed holiness and the collapse of trust in institutions.

Mara

Mara’s name echoes *marah*, bitterness. She stands in the ashes of her trust, like Zion in Eikhah: “She weeps bitterly in the night... there

is none to comfort her” (1:2). She is courageous enough to face the ruins, but vulnerable enough to be crushed by them.

The Stranger

The Stranger is Elijah-like: appearing at the threshold, not inside the ruin. This presence interrupts despair and insists that Mara not remain trapped. It echoes Lamentations 3:21: “This I call to mind, therefore I have hope.”

The Dove

The dove recalls the Talmud’s image of a *bat kol* moaning like a dove. It symbolizes Hashem’s grief and the world’s witness to suffering: “My eyes flow with rivers of tears... until the Lord looks down and sees” (3:48–50).

The Road

The road is movement, agency, and the possibility of healing. Elijah’s teaching—do not pray in the ruin, pray on the road—becomes a theology of motion. It resonates with Lamentations 5:21: “Turn us toward You... renew our days.”

7. Musical Arrangement Guide

What the Shruti Box Does

A shruti box produces a sustained drone — one note held continuously, with the option to add its fifth (the “Pa” reed). It does not play melodies or change pitch. Its job is to be the ground beneath the voices: steady, present, and breathing.

Before You Begin

Choose your key

Have the readers hum a comfortable pitch for the Lament. D minor or E minor are good starting points. Set the shruti box to that root note.

Open one or two reeds only

Root note alone for a spare sound. Root + fifth (“Pa”) for a fuller sound. Avoid opening more — less is more.

Controlling volume

Pump the bellows steadily for a full tone. Ease pressure for a softer sound. The drone should feel like breath — never louder than the voices.

Cue Plan

Cue	Dynamic	When
A	Soft	Begin drone before first word; hold beneath early narration
B	Swell gently	The dove’s cry — let drone rise slightly, then settle
C	Soft, steady	Beneath the Stranger’s lines
D	Swell	“A single honest word...” and Mara’s step forward
E	Full	“Lament” round — drone anchors the singers; continue beneath spoken laments

Cue	Dynamic	When
F	Fade to silence	Ease off bellows slowly; room holds quiet

8. Discussion Prompts

1. The Ruin — What “ruins” do you see in our world or in your own story?

2. The Stranger — Who has met you at the threshold of pain?

3. The Dove — What does it mean that Hashem cries with us?

4. The Road — What is one small step forward you feel willing to take?

5. Lament — What did you name, or want to name, in the circle of laments? How does naming grief alongside others change it?

6. Draw — Sketch something from the play: the dove, the ruin, the woman returning,

Elijah at the threshold...

